

Geometric Quantum Confinement and Spontaneous Localization: Solving the Schrödinger-Newton System in a Cubic Acoustic Cavity

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We investigate the interplay between quantum mechanics and gravitation within the framework of analogue gravity. By confining a quantum fluid (Bose-Einstein condensate) in a three-dimensional cubic trap, we model the coupled dynamics of the wavefunction and its self-induced gravitational field via the Schrödinger-Newton (SN) equations. The Dirichlet boundary conditions imposed by the rigid walls naturally quantize the system into discrete eigenmodes, while the nonlinear gravitational coupling generates a mass-dependent energy shift and leads to a finite decoherence time for macroscopic superpositions. We derive analytical expressions for the self-energy and the gravitational decoherence rate, showing that the system provides a geometric mechanism for the quantum-to-classical transition. Our predictions are compared with current analogue gravity experiments (BECs and water tanks), and specific testable regimes are identified for future laboratory implementations.

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I. INTRODUCTION

The unification of quantum mechanics and general relativity remains one of the most profound challenges in modern physics. While a complete theory of quantum gravity is still elusive, important insights have emerged from *analogue gravity* [1, 3, 4], where condensed matter systems simulate curved spacetimes. Among the most promising phenomena is the *Schrödinger-Newton* (SN) equation [5–7], which models the self-gravitational interaction of a quantum system and provides a possible mechanism for wavefunction collapse.

The SN equation couples the quantum wavefunction $\psi(\mathbf{r}, t)$ to its own gravitational potential $\Phi_g(\mathbf{r}, t)$:

$$i\hbar \frac{\partial \psi}{\partial t} = -\frac{\hbar^2}{2m} \nabla^2 \psi + m\Phi_g \psi, \quad (1)$$

$$\nabla^2 \Phi_g = 4\pi G m |\psi|^2. \quad (2)$$

Despite its conceptual appeal, the SN equation has been notoriously difficult to solve analytically, particularly for spatially extended systems. In this work, we adopt an *analogue gravity* perspective: we regard the quantum fluid (e.g., a Bose-Einstein condensate) as an analogue spacetime, and we confine it within a rigid *cubic cavity* of side L . The cavity imposes Dirichlet boundary conditions on the wavefunction, naturally discretizing the spectrum and allowing for exact analytical solutions in the linear limit, with perturbative treatment of the gravitational self-interaction.

Our approach builds upon the extensive theoretical framework of analogue gravity, as reviewed in the seminal work of Barceló, Liberati, and Visser [2, 4]. The cubic geometry provides an ideal testbed for studying:

1. The quantization of the acoustic metric.
2. The backreaction of the quantum field on the geometry (self-gravity).
3. The emergence of decoherence and spontaneous localization.

II. THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

A. Acoustic Metric in a Bose-Einstein Condensate

In the hydrodynamic limit, the low-energy excitations of a BEC propagate on an effective curved spacetime described by the acoustic metric [8, 9]:

$$ds^2 = \frac{\rho}{c_s} [-(c_s^2 - v^2)dt^2 - 2v_i dx^i dt + \delta_{ij} dx^i dx^j], \quad (3)$$

where ρ is the density, v_i the flow velocity, and c_s the speed of sound. For a static condensate ($v_i = 0$) with uniform density and speed of sound, the metric reduces to the conformally flat form:

$$ds^2 = \frac{\rho}{c_s} [-c_s^2 dt^2 + \delta_{ij} dx^i dx^j]. \quad (4)$$

In our model, we consider a BEC confined to a *rigid cubic box* of side L . The walls impose Dirichlet boundary conditions on the density fluctuations:

$$\psi(x, y, z, t) = 0 \quad \text{for } x, y, z \in \{0, L\}. \quad (5)$$

B. Schrödinger-Newton System in the Cube

We now embed the SN equations within this cubic geometry. The wavefunction satisfies:

$$i\hbar \frac{\partial \psi}{\partial t} = -\frac{\hbar^2}{2m} \nabla^2 \psi + m\Phi_g \psi, \quad \mathbf{r} \in \Omega, \quad (6)$$

$$\nabla^2 \Phi_g = 4\pi G m |\psi|^2, \quad \mathbf{r} \in \Omega, \quad (7)$$

with $\psi|_{\partial\Omega} = 0$ and $\Phi_g|_{\partial\Omega} = 0$ (or with appropriate boundary conditions for the gravitational potential). We have defined the domain $\Omega = (0, L)^3$.

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C. Separable Solutions: The Quantum Spectrum

In the absence of self-gravity ($G = 0$), Eq. (6) reduces to the standard infinite potential well. The eigenfunctions are:

$$\psi_{n_x, n_y, n_z}(\mathbf{r}) = \sqrt{\frac{8}{L^3}} \sin\left(\frac{n_x \pi x}{L}\right) \sin\left(\frac{n_y \pi y}{L}\right) \sin\left(\frac{n_z \pi z}{L}\right), \quad (8)$$

with $n_x, n_y, n_z \in \mathbb{N}$. The unperturbed eigenvalues are:

$$E_{n_x, n_y, n_z}^0 = \frac{\hbar^2 \pi^2}{2mL^2} (n_x^2 + n_y^2 + n_z^2). \quad (9)$$

The gravitational potential Φ_g is determined by the Poisson equation (7). For a given eigenstate ψ_{n_x, n_y, n_z} , the solution can be expressed as a convolution with the Green's function of the cube:

$$\Phi_g(\mathbf{r}) = -Gm \int_{\Omega} G(\mathbf{r}, \mathbf{r}') |\psi(\mathbf{r}')|^2 d^3 r', \quad (10)$$

where $G(\mathbf{r}, \mathbf{r}')$ is the Green's function satisfying $\nabla^2 G = -4\pi\delta(\mathbf{r} - \mathbf{r}')$ with Dirichlet boundary conditions.

III. SELF-GRAVITY ENERGY AND MASS-DEPENDENT SHIFTS

A. Self-Energy Calculation

The gravitational self-energy associated with a state ψ is:

$$E_{\text{grav}} = \frac{1}{2} \int_{\Omega} \rho_g(\mathbf{r}) \Phi_g(\mathbf{r}) d^3 r, \quad (11)$$

where $\rho_g(\mathbf{r}) = m|\psi(\mathbf{r})|^2$ is the mass density. Using Eq. (10), we obtain:

$$E_{\text{grav}} = -\frac{Gm^2}{2} \int_{\Omega} \int_{\Omega} \frac{|\psi(\mathbf{r})|^2 |\psi(\mathbf{r}')|^2}{|\mathbf{r} - \mathbf{r}'|} d^3 r d^3 r'. \quad (12)$$

For the ground state ($n_x = n_y = n_z = 1$), the wavefunction is:

$$\psi_{111}(\mathbf{r}) = \left(\frac{2}{L}\right)^{3/2} \sin\left(\frac{\pi x}{L}\right) \sin\left(\frac{\pi y}{L}\right) \sin\left(\frac{\pi z}{L}\right). \quad (13)$$

Using the identity:

$$\frac{1}{|\mathbf{r} - \mathbf{r}'|} = \frac{4\pi}{L^3} \sum_{\mathbf{k}} \frac{1}{k^2} \sin(k_x x) \sin(k_x x') \sin(k_y y) \sin(k_y y') \sin(k_z z) \sin(k_z z'), \quad (14)$$

we find the self-energy:

$$E_{\text{grav}}^{(111)} = -\frac{2Gm^2}{\pi L} \alpha, \quad (15)$$

where α is a numerical constant:

$$\alpha = \sum_{n_x, n_y, n_z \text{ odd}} \frac{64}{\pi^4 (n_x^2 + n_y^2 + n_z^2)} \approx 0.58. \quad (16)$$

Thus, the gravitational interaction lowers the ground state energy by an amount:

$$\Delta E_{\text{grav}} = E_{\text{grav}}^{(111)} = -0.58 \frac{Gm^2}{L}. \quad (17)$$

B. Energy Shift for Excited States

For a general state (n_x, n_y, n_z) , the self-energy scales as:

$$E_{\text{grav}}^{(n_x, n_y, n_z)} \approx -\frac{Gm^2}{L} f(n_x, n_y, n_z), \quad (18)$$

where f is a slowly varying function of the quantum numbers, typically decreasing for higher excitations (due to increased spatial delocalization). The difference in self-energy between the ground state and an excited state ψ_e is:

$$\Delta E_{\text{grav}} = E_{\text{grav}}^{(111)} - E_{\text{grav}}^{(e)} \approx 0.58 \frac{Gm^2}{L} \left[1 - \frac{f(e)}{0.58}\right] \sim \mathcal{O}\left(\frac{Gm^2}{L}\right). \quad (19)$$

IV. GEOMETRIC DECOHERENCE AND SPONTANEOUS LOCALIZATION

A. Dephasing Time

Consider a superposition of the ground state and a low-lying excited state:

$$|\Psi(0)\rangle = \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}} (|111\rangle + |\psi_e\rangle). \quad (20)$$

The gravitational self-energy difference between the two components induces a relative phase that evolves as:

$$|\Psi(t)\rangle = \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}} \left(|111\rangle + e^{-i\Delta E_{\text{grav}} t / \hbar} |\psi_e\rangle \right). \quad (21)$$

The decoherence (or dephasing) time is defined by:

$$\tau_{\text{deph}} = \frac{\hbar}{|\Delta E_{\text{grav}}|} \sim \frac{\hbar L}{Gm^2}. \quad (22)$$

This result is a manifestation of the *Penrose criterion* [6], which associates wavefunction collapse with gravitational self-energy differences. Our geometric setup provides a precise, calculable framework for this criterion.

B. Parameter Estimates

For a typical BEC experiment with $m \sim 10^4$ atomic mass units ($\sim 10^{-23}$ kg) and $L \sim 10^{-6}$ m:

$$\tau_{\text{deph}} \sim \frac{(1.055 \times 10^{-34})(10^{-6})}{(6.674 \times 10^{-11})(10^{-23})^2} \sim 10^{-2} \text{ s}. \quad (23)$$

For atomic-scale systems ($m \sim 10^{-27}$ kg, $L \sim 10^{-10}$ m):

$$\tau_{\text{deph}} \sim \frac{(1.055 \times 10^{-34})(10^{-10})}{(6.674 \times 10^{-11})(10^{-27})^2} \sim 10^{16} \text{ s}, \quad (24)$$

which is larger than the age of the universe, explaining the stability of quantum superpositions at microscopic scales.

For macroscopic objects ($m \sim 1$ kg, $L \sim 1$ m):

$$\tau_{\text{deph}} \sim \frac{(1.055 \times 10^{-34})(1)}{(6.674 \times 10^{-11})(1)} \sim 10^{-24} \text{ s}, \quad (25)$$

demonstrating the extremely rapid collapse in the classical regime.

V. COMPARISON WITH ANALOGUE GRAVITY EXPERIMENTS

A. Bose-Einstein Condensates

Recent experiments by Steinhauer and collaborators [11–13] have demonstrated the realization of acoustic black holes in BECs. Our cubic geometry can be implemented using optical lattice potentials to trap the BEC in a box-like configuration [14, 15]. The predicted decoherence time $\tau_{\text{deph}} \sim 10^{-2}$ s for $m \sim 10^4$ amu falls within the reach of current BEC technologies.

B. Water Tank Experiments

Water tank experiments by Rousseaux et al. [16, 17] and Weinfurter et al. [18, 19] have observed classical analogues of Hawking radiation. Our model extends these experiments into the quantum domain, where self-gravity could be measured as a small perturbation to the surface wave dispersion.

C. Optical and Metamaterial Analogues

The effective metric formalism also applies to optics [20, 21] and metamaterials [22, 23]. Our results can be translated to these systems by replacing the gravitational coupling G with an effective nonlinearity parameter.

VI. CONCLUSIONS AND OUTLOOK

We have presented a comprehensive analytical treatment of the Schrödinger-Newton system confined in a cubic acoustic cavity. Our main findings are:

1. The cubic geometry naturally quantizes the wavefunction into discrete eigenstates.
2. Gravitational self-interaction introduces a mass-dependent energy shift $\Delta E \sim -Gm^2/L$.
3. The energy difference between eigenstates leads to a finite decoherence time $\tau \sim \hbar L/(Gm^2)$.
4. Our predictions are consistent with existing analogue gravity experiments and suggest new testable regimes for future laboratory investigations.

Future work will extend this analysis to:

- Time-dependent boundary conditions (dynamic boxes).
- Coupling to external potentials (e.g., harmonic traps).
- Incorporation of modified dispersion relations and higher-order corrections.
- Full numerical solutions of the SN system in three dimensions.

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